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Trading in Trust

How Documentation Protects People, Not Just Projects

Stephan Rayner · Grafana Labs



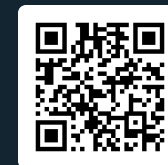
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Trading in Trust: How Documentation Protects People, Not Just Projects

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SCAN TO CONNECT

OPENING

Documentation Isn't Just a Reference Artifact

- It's trust infrastructure.
- Its job is to inform, and to preserve the conditions under which people can work together honestly.

Without it, power fills the **vacuum**, and
the loudest voice wins.

TWO STORIES

Opposite Ends of the Same Dynamic

- One where the absence of documentation let power win.
- One where documentation itself was the power.

STORY ONE

Head of Data at a Toxic, Now Defunct Mobile Games Company

- A team of analysts and data engineers.
- Stakeholders who wanted data, on their terms.

The Newest Person Is the Easiest to Pressure

- Stakeholders leaned on whoever was junior enough to say yes.

Demand Data from the New Analyst

Greg (Head of Business Development) vs. Analina (Junior Analyst)

- Ask: I want tutorial completion data sliced the following way.
- Consequence: We are going to be millionaires!!! 🎉💰
 - 89% D1 in a free-to-play mobile game.

No Written Standard, No Cover

- What data could be shared, in what form, and why: never documented.
- Every request became a negotiation an analyst had to win alone.

The org chart, not the **policy**, decided who won.

STORY ONE

Solution: How We Addressed This

- Written request filing process in a tool we already used.
- Event Schema Docs for Stakeholders
 - What this event is.
 - Why we capture this event.
 - What you can't get from this event (common fails).
 - When this event is triggered.
- This gave the Analysts both a platform and a shield.

STORY TWO

The Arrogant Senior ML Engineer Who Lost to an Expense Policy

- This one's on me.

I Argued Anyway

- Me (Senior Machine Learning Engineer) vs. Ronnie (Junior Expense Analyst).
- I wanted an exception.
- The policy said no.
- I was sure I could talk my way around it.

The document won on its own, because it was written for exactly this **moment**.

EXPENSE POLICY, SECTION 4.2 (REDACTED)

"No exceptions will be made for [REDACTED], regardless of role, tenure, or seniority."

THE MECHANISM

Good Documentation Externalizes Authority

- It levels a playing field otherwise decided by power, clout, or seniority.
- Without a difficult conversation every single time.

TRADING IN TRUST

We Trade in Trust, Not Documents

- If people don't trust our documents, it doesn't matter how many we write.
- If they can't use our documents, they won't trust them.

THE FRAMEWORK

Four Ways to Write Docs That Do This Work

- 1 Write for the enforcer, not just the reader
- 2 Anchor to mission rather than procedure
- 3 Document the why alongside the what
- 4 Make your limitations visible

Write for the Enforcer, Not Just the Reader

- The reader wants to know what to do.
- The enforcer has to hold the line when someone pushes back.
- Ask: if someone argues, what does the enforcer say next?

Anchor to Mission Rather Than Procedure

- Procedure only covers the cases someone thought of.
- Mission lets people reason from it when the case isn't covered.
- Ask: if the steps run out, does the mission tell you what to do next?

Document the Why Alongside the What

- Rules without reasoning invite argument.
- An unreasoned rule looks arbitrary, and arbitrary rules feel challengeable.
-  One sentence of reasoning next to every rule.

Make Your Limitations Visible

- A doc that names what it doesn't cover builds more trust than one that oversells.
- Ask: what doesn't this document cover, and have you said so?

Good News We Are Almost Done!

CLOSE

A document can be a **leveler and a shield**: it fills the vacuum once, and holds the line long after you've left the room.



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